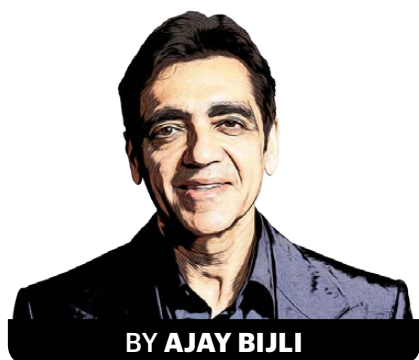




BY AJAY BIJLI

A Great Leap Forward

India is emerging as a blockbuster nation and in this path towards development, the role of cinema, entertainment and multiplexes cannot be overstated

INDIA WILL EMERGE as the blockbuster nation across numerous parameters in the next five years. As someone who has been actively involved with two of the country's most dynamic growth drivers—retail and entertainment, this will unfold across the board till 2029 and beyond.

The way the movie business has bounced back post-Covid has left a deep imprint in the minds of Indian audiences. And they have come out in droves to the cinemas to create benchmarks of success across the board. In 2022, *RRR* and *KGF* brought people back to the cinemas, and 2023's top grossers, from *Barbie* and *Oppenheimer* to *Jailor* and *Leo* to *Pathaan* and *Jawan* to *12th Pass*, *Animal*, and *Sam Bahadur* are just a taste of things to unfold over this decade.

India is already the world's most populous country, and the leapfrogging effect of policy reforms, effective infrastructure, combined with entrepreneurial zeal is already fueling the journey towards a \$5-trillion economy in the near future.

With almost 65% of the population below the age of 35, we now have a young mass market with niches like young luxury, and aspiring youth as both consuming and producing segments. In the space of retail and entertainment, this plays out as what I call the 3M experience—Mall, Meal and Movie. So, when a consumer goes to shop at a mall, she also has a meal and watches a movie. So, if she goes to shop at a mall with global brands, she will also expect to have a meal at a Michelin Star restaurant and luxury movie spaces. Similarly, in the aspirational districts across the country, and in the newly emerg-

ing urbanised context, that mix would have more aspiring brands.

Today, the Indian consumer is earning well and spending well. With increasing per capita income, their spending capability has also grown.

With deeper penetration of brands and entertainment through 5/6G telecom, the emergence of demand pan-India for better retail and entertainment experiences will not only bolster local economies through massive job creation but also change consumer habits. Both retail and entertainment are among the largest employers in the country, and this

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INDIA IS ALREADY ON TRACK TO BECOME A \$5-TRILLION ECONOMY THANKS TO GOVERNMENTAL REFORMS, GOOD INFRASTRUCTURE, AND ENTREPRENEURIAL SPIRIT